

couple married in 1899, but their relationship ran into trouble when Debussy fell under the spell of the bewitching singer Emma Bardac. She had already been the mistress of the composer Gabriel Fauré and, in 1904, Debussy abandoned his wife to be with her. Distraught, Lily attempted suicide a few days before their fifth anniversary. She survived, but the incident left a permanent stain on the composer's reputation. Many of his friends disowned him and the press reaction was universally hostile.

Debussy's later years were clouded by illness. From 1909, he began to suffer from the cancer that would eventually kill him. As a result of the illness, he endured one of the earliest colostomy operations ever performed. He died in Paris at the end of World War I, with the sound of German shells echoing in the streets nearby.



MARY GARDEN AS MELISANDE